What Turns Up in Mom's Mail

Everyday paper to notice and note, with her permission.

You're at Mom's on a Sunday and there's a small stack of mail on the counter. Most of it is ordinary. Some of it shows, a piece at a time, what she has, what comes in and what goes out.

This guide names fifteen everyday things worth noticing over the coming months, most of them paper, and, for each, what to write down. Ask Mom first. It's her mail, and the noticing is something to do with her.

Notice and note. Don't interpret. What a paper means for paying for care is a question for a professional, and the answer varies by state. The kinds of paper listed here follow lists published by the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, AARP and the Family Caregiver Alliance; the wording about what to write down is ours.

Money coming in

1 Social Security mail and deposits [1]

NOTICE A letter from Social Security, or the deposit line on Mom's bank statement.

WRITE DOWN Who pays it, the amount as printed, and where the letter is kept.

2 Pension and retirement plan mail [1]

NOTICE A statement or benefit summary from a former employer's plan or a retirement account.

WRITE DOWN The plan or company's name, how often something arrives, and where Mom keeps it.

3 Other regular deposits [4]

NOTICE An annuity payment, rent from a tenant, or another deposit that shows up on a statement again and again.

WRITE DOWN Who pays it and how often. Copy amounts as printed; don't estimate.

Accounts

4 Bank statements [2]

NOTICE Which banks send them, on paper or by email, and the names printed at the top.

WRITE DOWN The bank, the kind of account, the names as printed, and where the statements go.

5 Brokerage and investment statements [2]

NOTICE An envelope from a brokerage or fund company, or the name of a person Mom says handles her investments.

WRITE DOWN The firm, a contact name if there is one, and where the latest statement is.

6 A name you don't recognize [2]

NOTICE Mail from a bank, an insurer or a company that isn't on your list yet, including one Mom used years ago.

WRITE DOWN The name on the envelope and the date. Ask Mom about it before anything is opened.

7 Tax paperwork [2]

NOTICE Envelopes marked as tax documents, and whether Mom does her own return or has someone prepare it.

WRITE DOWN Where the recent returns are kept, and the preparer's name and number if there is one.

Insurance and property

8 Premium notices and renewals [2]

NOTICE A bill or renewal from an insurance company: life, health, long-term care, home or vehicle.

WRITE DOWN The company, the kind of policy, and where the policy itself is kept. Not what it covers.

9 Something Mom mentions in passing

NOTICE “I've had that policy for years.” “There's still something from the old job.” A remark over coffee can name a paper nobody has seen in a while.

WRITE DOWN Her words, the date, and what she remembers about where the paper is.

10 Paper about the house [2]

NOTICE A property tax bill, a homeowner's insurance renewal, a mortgage or home equity loan statement.

WRITE DOWN The property, the lender if there is one, and where the deed is kept.

11 Vehicle paperwork [2] [3]

NOTICE A registration renewal in the mail, or the title in a drawer.

WRITE DOWN The vehicle, and where its title and registration are.

Money going out

12 Regular bills [2]

NOTICE Which bills arrive in the mail, and which never arrive because they're paid automatically.

WRITE DOWN Each automatic payment, and the account or card it comes from.

13 Loan and credit card statements [1]

NOTICE A statement from a lender or a card company.

WRITE DOWN The lender or card company, and where the statements are kept.

The paper and the people

14 Where the paper lands [3]

NOTICE The counter, the desk drawer, the file box, the email inbox. Notice where each kind of paper ends up once it's been read.

WRITE DOWN The place for each kind, including a safe deposit box if she has one.

15 Who already helps [3]

NOTICE Who opens the mail, who pays the bills, who does the taxes, and whether there's an insurance agent, an accountant or an attorney Mom calls.

WRITE DOWN Each name, what they do, and a phone number.

When a note isn't enough

If a paper asks Mom to do something and neither of you is sure what, the company or office that sent it is the first call. Questions about what any of this means for paying for care, or for Medicaid in her state, go to your Medicaid planner. Questions about ownership or legal documents go to an elder law attorney. And if a statement shows payments Mom doesn't recognize, the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's advice is to look into them rather than set them aside; her bank is the place to start.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these papers mean, what Mom's finances add up to, or whether anything should change. It isn't legal, financial or tax advice. A professional who knows her state does that work, and does it better with your notes in front of them.

Ready for the next step?

You know which papers to notice and how to note them. The planning interview gives those notes somewhere to go: it asks about your family's situation in an orderly way and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
2. AARP, 5 Steps to Organize Your Loved One's Financial Records
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Where to Find My Important Papers
4. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney